The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Anadolu via Getty Images

Oil prices rose ahead of negotiations between **Iran** and **America** in Geneva on Tuesday. Donald Trump said he would be “indirectly” involved in the talks about Iran’s nuclear programme. Earlier America deployed a second aircraft-carrier to the Middle East, raising tensions. On Monday Iran’s foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, held talks with the International Atomic Energy Agency, the UN’s nuclear watchdog.

BHP, the world’s biggest mining company by market capitalisation, reported stronger-than-expected half-year results, driven by soaring demand for copper. The Australian group said revenue rose by 11% year on year to $27.9bn in the six months to the end of December. Net profit rose by nearly 30%. Shares in the company opened 7.5% higher.

Lawmakers in New Mexico passed legislation to launch an investigation into Zorro Ranch, a mansion owned by **Jeffrey Epstein**. The dead sex offender allegedly trafficked and abused girls and women there. A bipartisan committee will investigate which ranch guests and state officials may have known. Meanwhile Thomas Pritzker, a hotel magnate, stepped down as Hyatt’s executive chair after documents revealed his ties to Epstein.

Ed Miliband, Britain's energy secretary, and **Gavin Newsom**, California's Democratic governor, signed a clean-energy partnership, promising to share technology and attract joint investment. Octopus Energy, a British green-power group, pledged to invest $1bn in Californian renewables, storage and carbon-removal projects. Mr Trump, who has loosened America's greenhouse-gas regulations, criticised the pact as "inappropriate" and urged Britain not to "get involved" with Mr Newsom.

The **Federal Reserve** plans to relax capital rules for American banks to encourage more mortgage lending, Michelle Bowman, its vice-chair for supervision, said. The changes would let banks adjust the capital they hold to reflect a loan's risk, rather than apply a single standard for all mortgages. Officials argue that strict rules have pushed activity to non-bank lenders.

Hapag-Lloyd, the world's fifth-largest container-shipping group, agreed to buy ZIM, an **Israeli** competitor, for $4.2bn. Carriers ordered record numbers of ships during the pandemic, but freight rates have now slumped and the industry is consolidating. Staff at ZIM went on strike to oppose the merger with the German company and Israeli officials raised national-security concerns. Israel's competition authority will review the deal.

Robert Duvall, an American actor who played roles in "The Godfather", "To Kill a Mockingbird" and "Apocalypse Now", died aged 95. His wife said he passed away "peacefully" at his home in Virginia. Known for meticulous preparation and the variety of characters he portrayed, he won an Academy Award for "Tender Mercies" and received seven Oscar nominations during a career spanning more than six decades.

Figure of the day: 1.7m, the number of people in India who die from causes related to bad air every year. Read the full story.

Photograph: dpa

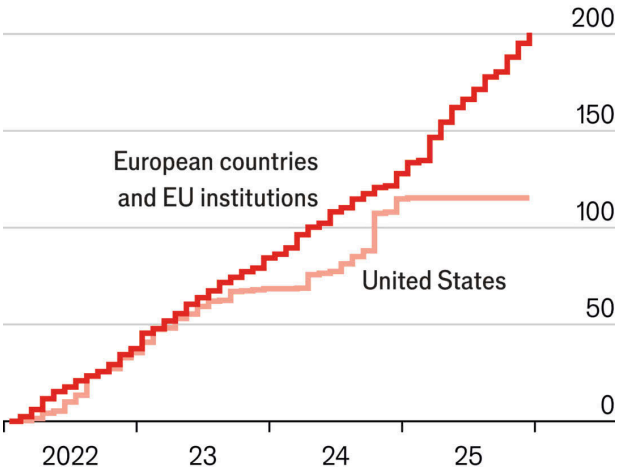
Trump piles pressure on Ukraine ahead of talks

Another round of peace talks between America, Ukraine and Russia gets under way in Geneva on Tuesday. Prospects are dim. Donald Trump has demanded that Ukraine hold both presidential elections and a referendum on a peace deal by mid-May or lose any proposed American security commitments. But holding an election in Ukraine while the country is at war would be impossible both for practical and security reasons. Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine's president, has said that elections could only take place two months after a ceasefire agreement and when "all the relevant security guarantees" are in place.

Equally, Mr Zelensky warned recently that Vladimir Putin "is no longer interested in anything" except war. Russia, he says, only "hears strength". Europe appears to be stepping up to give Ukraine that strength. At a meeting last week it pledged a further $38bn in military aid. Last year, after Mr Trump took office, America's military aid for Ukraine fell by 99%.

Up in arms

Allocated bilateral aid to Ukraine, cumulative, €bn



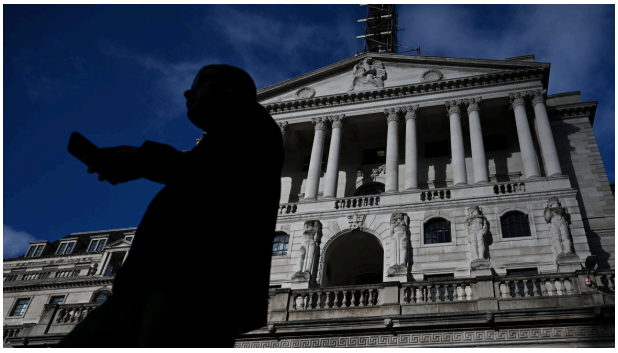
Source: Kiel Institute

Photograph: Reuters

Emmanuel Macron jets to India

On Tuesday in Mumbai Emmanuel Macron began a three-day visit to India, his fourth as president of France. He is travelling with a big business delegation, and is hoping to finalise contracts, among them an order for 114 Rafale fighter jets built by Dassault, a French firm. The Indian armed forces already use the Rafale, and ordered more last year. On Thursday France's president will attend an AI summit in New Delhi.

The visit is also part of an effort to reinforce Mr Macron's Indo-Pacific strategy, which shifted in 2021 after the AUKUS submarine deal between America, Australia and Britain sank a French security agreement with Australia. France's new ties to India, which include joint military exercises, have a fresh importance: European countries, doubting the reliability of Donald Trump's America, are seeking to diversify alliances.



Photograph: Getty Images

The Bank of England's opportunity to cut rates

A flurry of statistical releases this week could strengthen the case for the Bank of England to cut interest rates next month. Labour-market figures out on Tuesday are expected to show that the unemployment rate rose to 5.2% in the last quarter of 2025—a five-year high. Combined with last week's weak GDP data, that gives doves at the bank ample ammunition to argue for cutting the main policy rate from 3.75% to 3.5%.

Similarly, the bank expects figures released on Wednesday to show that annual price growth fell from 3.4% in December to 2.9% in January. It reckons that by April inflation will at last have returned to the bank's 2% target, helped by government measures to reduce energy costs. The Monetary Policy Committee narrowly voted against cutting rates this month. But this week's data may give it enough cause to do so when it next meets in March.

Photograph: Shutterstock

Spenders and spies at Chinese new year

People with Chinese roots, both inside and outside China, will celebrate the lunar new year, which begins on Tuesday, with fireworks, family reunions and feasts. Pyrotechnics are banned in parts of China, but the authorities want people to splurge on other pleasures—weak consumer spending has been restraining economic growth. The year of the horse holiday is nine days long, instead of the usual eight. The government hopes this will encourage tourists to spend more.

It is also the Year of the Spy. The Ministry of State Security, China's main civilian intelligence agency, has helped make a film, "Scare Out", whose release coincides with the festivities. The thriller is billed as China's first film based on real, contemporary espionage. It ends with an appeal to audiences to report suspicious behaviour by calling an official hotline. State media say ticket sales look strong.

Photograph: Getty Images

Gisele Pelicot tells her own story

Gisèle Pelicot became a global feminist icon in 2024 when she waived her right to anonymity, allowing the trial of the men who raped her to be a public one. Dominique Pelicot, her husband, was found guilty of repeatedly drugging and raping her. Fifty other men invited by Mr Pelicot to abuse his wife were convicted of rape or assault alongside him.

On Tuesday Ms Pelicot's memoir, "A Hymn to Life", will be published in 22 languages. In it, she recounts the nightmare of discovering that her husband of 50 years was not who he appeared to be. She writes that "shame has to change sides", from the victims of sexual violence to its perpetrators. Despite the horrifying specifics of her story, readers will respond to its universal themes of loss, memory and longing for love. Ms Pelicot's courage and dignity have helped broaden the legal definition of rape in France. It now includes any sexual act done without consent.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily Quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Grey, blood and basset are words that precede the name of what type of dog?

Monday: What colour, traditionally worn by a cardinal, is also associated with a childhood disease?

If you want to increase your success rate, double your failure rate.

Thomas J. Watson